



WHERE THE UNHERALDED TOOK CENTRE STAGE

The Khelo India Beach Games offered **visibility and belief** to athletes and sports that rarely find space in the spotlight.

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The second edition of the Khelo India Beach Games saw more than 1,100 athletes competing across six medal disciplines: beach soccer, beach kabaddi, beach sepak takraw, beach pencak silat, open water swimming, and beach volleyball. Tug of war and beach mallakhamb also featured as demonstration events.

The six-day event concluded with Karnataka finishing on top, driven by a dominant showing in open water swimming, where it won eight medals, including three gold. The state ended its campaign with 11 medals overall.

Tamil Nadu finished a close second with eight medals — three gold, two silver, and three bronze — with all four of its beach volleyball teams returning with medals. Manipur, which had topped the medal table last year, finished third with seven medals, powered by strong performances in pencak silat and sepak takraw.

The unheralded come to the fore

At the heart of the event lies the idea of giving a platform for lesser-known sports and athletes. Under the Khelo India banner, these disciplines are provided a structured, competitive environment — one where visibility, quality, and stakes coexist.

“Khelo India itself is a brand that is reputed across India,” explained Karunesh Kumar, Competition Manager for beach sepak takraw. “This event gives exposure to sports that are very exciting and offer plenty of opportunities, but whose names can be a tongue twister. In India, people tend to think simple things are better than complex ones, but this platform gives exposure to our athletes so that people can see the energy and effort that goes into the sport.”

This is especially significant for athletes for whom competitive opportunities — at any level — are limited. Rohith Yesudas, a member of Kerala’s gold medal-winning beach soccer side and the Indian beach soccer team, pointed out that between the two editions of the Beach Games, chances to play have been few and far between.